seas; losing that control would make fulfilling alliance commitments even more difficult or costly.

Recovering our appreciation of the strategic importance of Asia's inner seas and rimlands is necessary if America is to devise a realistic strategy to preserve both its power and its influence in the Indo-Pacific. Losing one part of the Asiatic Mediterranean will certainly cause allies and partners in other parts to consider either severing ties with the United States or declaring neutrality so as to preserve their own freedom of action. A geopolitically isolated United States is an operationally weakened United States. Being pushed out of one sea will require the US military to expend national treasure to fight its way back in during a crisis. The better course of action is to keep the Asiatic Mediterranean whole, balanced, and stable. Only then can America be certain that the vital rimlands of Asia will remain free from conflict. To paraphrase Benjamin Franklin, the Asiatic Mediterranean must certainly hang together, or it might very well hang separately.

Notes

1. Associated Press, "China Seeks to Control East Asia, US Commander Tells Senators," *The Guardian*, February 23, 2016, https://www.theguardian.com/world/2016/feb/23/south-china-sea-east-asia-control-us-military.
2. US Pacific Command was renamed US Indo-Pacific Command in May 2018.
3. Shirley A. Kan, *China: Suspected Acquisition of U.S. Nuclear Weapon Secrets*, RL30143 (Washington, DC: US Library of Congress, Congressional Research Service, 2006), https://fas.org/sgp/crs/nuke/RL30143.pdf.
4. See, for example, Edward Wong and Jonathan Ansfield, "To Bolster Its Claims, China Plants Islands in Disputed Waters," *New York Times*, June 16, 2014, https://www.nytimes.com/2014/06/17/world/asia/spratly-archipelago-china-trying-to-bolster-its-claims-plants-islands-in-disputed-waters.html.